

B2B SALES ESSENTIALS

B2B Sales Essentials — Level 1 — Day 4: Several Decision Makers: Stakeholders, Objections, and Price Conversations

Study guide · Self-study

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How to Use This Guide

This is Day 4 of your Level 1 self-study series. You work through it alone, at your own pace, and you write in it as you go. Reading it once will not change how you sell. Writing your own answers, then saying them out loud, will.

The guide follows a simple rhythm in every section: explain, example, reflect. First you get the idea and the buyer psychology behind it. Then you see it in a worked B2B situation. Then you reflect on your own deals and practice the words.

Before you read any model answer, write your own. The model answers at the end are examples, not scripts. Your words should sound like you.

In the first three days you learned to research a client, reach the right person, and run discovery on business problems and the cost of doing nothing. Today builds on all three. In B2B, the person you spoke to on Day 3 is rarely the only one who decides. Today you learn to map everyone who matters, handle objections from each of them, and talk about price without giving ground too early.

Plan to spend a few short sittings on this guide rather than one long one. Keep a notebook or a document open for your written answers.

Today's Objectives (KASU)

Knowledge: You will know how a B2B decision-making unit is structured, the four friction blocks behind most objections, and why "the price is too high" is rarely a final statement about money.

Attitude: You will treat every stakeholder as a person with their own risk and their own reason to say no, and treat price objections as an invitation to understand value, not as an attack to survive.

Skill: You will be able to map the stakeholders in a deal, diagnose an objection from the client's own words, and hold a price conversation that connects the number to an outcome.

Upskill: You will be able to run a price conversation with more than one stakeholder in the room, keep your composure when two of them push in different directions, and leave with one agreed next step.

Mapping the Decision-Making Unit

In B2B, a deal is almost never one person. A typical decision involves several people, each with a different job, a different worry, and a different definition of a good outcome. If you only build a relationship with your first contact, you are selling to one room in a building full of rooms.

Think about who tends to appear in a business purchase:

- The user: the person who will work with what you sell every day. They care about whether it makes their job easier or harder.
- The manager or budget holder: the person who signs. They care about cost, risk, and how the decision reflects on them.
- The technical or process gatekeeper: the person who checks that it fits existing systems, rules, or workflows. They care about disruption.

- The finance contact: the person who releases the money. They care about timing, terms, and predictability.
- The executive sponsor: the senior person whose support makes the deal possible. They care about the business result, not the details.
- Each of these people answers a different silent question. The user asks, "Will this make my day better or worse?" The budget holder asks, "Can I defend this spend?" The gatekeeper asks, "What could go wrong?" The finance contact asks, "When does the money leave and when does it come back?" When you know which question each person is asking, you know what evidence each one needs.
- The buyer psychology here is simple: people protect their own position first. A manager who approves a purchase that later fails carries the blame. A gatekeeper who lets in a tool that breaks a process carries the blame. Their caution is not obstruction. It is self-protection, and it is rational. When you respect it, they relax. When you push past it, they dig in.
- Mapping is not a one-time task. People join deals late. A new finance director appears in week three. Your contact goes on leave. Ask early, "Who else would want a view on this?" and ask again at each stage.
- Practice example: You sell scheduling software to a regional logistics company. Your contact is an operations coordinator. Through questions you learn that her team lead approves the trial, the IT manager checks data security, and the finance controller releases the annual budget in the first week of each quarter. You note all four names, their questions, and what each one needs to see.
- Reflect: Think of one deal you have touched, even as an observer. Write down every person who has appeared in it so far. Next to each name, write the silent question you think they are asking. Leave a line for people you have not met yet.

The Safety Reflex and the Four Friction Blocks

Many objections are a fast, automatic reaction rather than a considered, final decision. Kahneman's fast and slow thinking describes two modes: a quick, intuitive judgment and a slower, deliberate evaluation. When a choice suddenly feels unsafe, the fast mode puts the brakes on before the slow mode has looked at anything. That is why a client can object to something they have not yet examined.

When a concern is emotional, more facts often increase resistance rather than reduce it. A client who feels risk does not need another number. They need to feel heard first. Acknowledge the concern before you introduce data. Their hesitation is a felt sense of risk, not a missing figure.

Most objections fall into one of four friction blocks. Diagnose from the client's own words, not from a guess.

Comparison Confusion: the client is measuring your offer against a mismatched benchmark. They compare a full-service option with a stripped-down one, or a small pilot with a large rollout. Test it with: "What are you comparing it with?"

Trust Deficit: the client is unsure of the process, the paperwork, or what happens after they sign, not the product itself. They ask small, unrelated questions to stall. Test it with: "Which part of the process feels least clear right now?"

Regret Avoidance: fear of making the wrong call makes freezing feel safer than deciding. "Let's wait and see what the market does" is the classic line. Test it with: "What would you need to know to feel confident either way?"

Value Disconnect: the price was never connected to an outcome the client cares about. The number exists on its own. Test it with: "What would you need to see to know it was worth it?"

One objection can carry more than one block. A finance contact who says the price is high may have a genuine value disconnect and a trust deficit about your terms. Ask one clarifying question, listen, and let their answer tell you which block is in front of you.

A caution: a repeated, firm refusal is a real decision, not a reflex. Respect it.

Practice example: A client says, "Your platform costs more than the one we looked at last year." You ask, "What are you comparing it with?" She describes a basic tool with no onboarding support. You now know this is Comparison Confusion, not a budget problem.

Reflect: Write down the last objection you heard from a real client or from a role-play. Which block do you think it was? What clarifying question would have told you for certain?

"The Price Is Too High": The Fallacy of Literal Cost

When a client says the price is too high, they are rarely making a final statement about what they can afford. Usually it means the weight of the decision currently feels larger than the value they can see. If you defend the number with more numbers, you treat it as a dispute about a figure. The real issue is perceived value or perceived risk.

Two common mistakes, and what to do instead:

- Lowering the price at the first objection: clarify what the objection is actually about before you move anything.
- Defending the number with more numbers: connect the number to the outcome the client wants.
- This is where the four friction blocks pay off. Before you respond to a price objection, ask one clarifying question to find out which block you are facing. Then you respond to the real issue.
- For the objection itself, use A.R.T., MEDJAY's own framework for handling objections and concerns: Acknowledge, Reframe, Transition. Always in that order, as one chain.
- Acknowledge means you label the client's feeling, with no "but" after it. "It sounds like the number feels hard to justify right now." Naming a feeling calms it, which is why this comes first.
- Reframe means you shift the decision criterion from the visible cost to the cost of inaction. You do not defend features. You help the client see what staying where they are actually costs them, in terms they already gave you in discovery.

- Transition means you ask a calibrated how or what question. Never a yes/no close, never a trade, never a concession.
- Practice example: A client says your service fee is too high. You say: "It sounds like the fee feels like a lot to commit to right now. The team is currently losing two days a month to manual reconciliation, which is time your operations lead told me you cannot get back. What would you need to see in the numbers to know whether the fee pays for itself?"
- Reflect: Take the price objection you wrote down in the previous section. Write an A.R.T. response to it in your own words. Make sure your Transition is a how or what question, not a yes/no.

Stakeholder Objections and the Mandatory Pause

Different stakeholders object in different ways. The user says it will slow them down. The manager says it costs too much. The gatekeeper says it does not fit the system. The finance contact says the timing is wrong. Each is protecting something different, so each needs a different piece of evidence. That is why mapping the decision-making unit comes before objection handling: the map tells you who is in the room and what they are protecting.

When an objection lands sharply, your body reacts first. Stress raises your heart rate, and it can raise your vocal pitch. Once that reactivity is audible, the client has two things to react to: their concern and your stress. That makes everything harder for both of you.

The Mandatory Pause (MEDJAY adaptation, based on Voss and Raz) gives you a few seconds after stating a fee or after a sharp objection before you speak again. It does two things. It lets you settle your breathing and your voice. It also signals to the client that you are considering what they said rather than reaching for a script. If you want a fast way to calm your body in real time, the physiological sigh works: two inhales through the nose, then one long, slow exhale through the mouth.

Composure is not performing calm to hide information, and it is not ignoring a legitimate refusal. The pause gives the objection a fair hearing. It does not guarantee a different outcome.

Practice example: A finance controller says, "We cannot afford this until next year." You pause, breathe out slowly, and say: "It sounds like the timing is the real problem here. If the spend started in the new budget year, what would the finance team need to see to approve it now?"

Reflect: The next time you hear an objection, notice your own breathing before you answer. Write one sentence about what you felt. Then write the first sentence you would say after the pause.

Apply It in Your Role

If you are in outside sales, ask your contact for a short walk-through of who touches this decision before you present anything. Ask to meet them, even briefly.

If you are in inside sales or on the phone, map the decision-making unit out loud in your notes after every call. Ask, "Who else would want a view on this?" before you hang up.

If you shadow a senior colleague, watch how they handle a price objection. Note whether they asked a clarifying question first or defended the number.

With every stakeholder, use the same three moves: find their silent question, diagnose the friction block from their own words, and answer with the evidence that matches their concern.

What Would You Say?

Write your answer to each situation before you look at the Model Answers. Keep each answer short and in your own words.

1. Your main contact at a manufacturing business says, "Honestly, I love it, but our finance director will say it's too expensive." Write your A.R.T. response.

2. During a call, the IT manager says, "We've been burned before by a supplier who promised integration and didn't deliver." Write your first two sentences.

3. A procurement manager says your rate is higher than a competitor's. You suspect Comparison Confusion. Write the clarifying question you would ask, then a full A.R.T. chain.

4. A stakeholder you have never met joins a meeting and says, "I have five minutes. Why are we here?" Write your opening.

5. After you state the fee, the room goes quiet. Write what you do and say next.

Key Takeaways

- B2B decisions involve several stakeholders, each protecting their own position and asking a different silent question.
- Many objections are a fast safety reflex, not a considered decision; acknowledge the concern before you bring data.
- The four friction blocks are Comparison Confusion, Trust Deficit, Regret Avoidance, and Value Disconnect; diagnose from the client's words.
- "The price is too high" usually means the weight of the decision exceeds the value the client sees, not that they cannot pay.
- A.R.T., MEDJAY's own framework, is Acknowledge, Reframe, Transition, always as one chain, with a calibrated how or what question at the end.
- The Mandatory Pause gives you a few seconds to settle your voice before you answer a sharp objection.

Quiz

Answer all five questions. Write your answers down before you check the key.

1. In a B2B deal, which of these best describes the decision-making unit?

A. The single person who signs the contract

B. Every stakeholder who influences or approves the decision

C. The person who first answered your call

D. The procurement team only

2. A client says, "Let's wait and see how the year goes." Which friction block are they most likely showing?

   A. Comparison Confusion

   B. Value Disconnect

   C. Regret Avoidance

   D. Trust Deficit

3. A client says, "Your price is too high." What is the strongest first move?

   A. Offer a discount before they ask again

   B. Ask a clarifying question to find out what the objection is really about

   C. List every feature to justify the number

   D. Walk away and try again next quarter

4. In A.R.T., what does the Transition step always use?

   A. A yes/no close to test commitment

   B. A trade or concession

   C. A calibrated how or what question

   D. A summary of features

5. What is the purpose of the Mandatory Pause after a sharp objection?

   A. To make the client uncomfortable

   B. To give you time to prepare a discount

   C. To settle your breathing and voice, and show you are considering what was said

   D. To hide information from the client

Upskill Challenge

Before Day 5, do the following in your first weeks in the role, with the support you have:

- Map the decision-making unit for two deals you are observing or working on with a colleague. Write each stakeholder's name, role, and silent question.
- In one of those deals, ask your contact, "Who else would want a view on this?" Note what you learn.
- Pick one objection you hear this week. Write the friction block, the clarifying question you used, and your A.R.T. response.
- Practice the Mandatory Pause once in a real conversation. Write one sentence on how it felt.
- Write which step of A.R.T. felt weakest, and what happened when you used it.
- Fill in as you go:
- Deal one, stakeholders: ____

- Deal one, clarifying question used: ____
- Deal one, A.R.T. response: ____
- Deal two, stakeholders: ____
- What I learned from asking who else wants a view: ____
- How the Mandatory Pause felt: ____
- Weakest A.R.T. step, and what happened: ____

Model Answers

1. "It sounds like the finance director's sign-off is the real gate here. If the director is weighing the cost today against what the delay keeps costing the plant, the question changes from what it costs to what waiting costs. What would the director need to see to feel confident signing off this quarter?" Why it works: it acknowledges the concern, reframes from cost to the cost of inaction, and transitions with a how or what question.

2. "That sounds frustrating, and I understand why you would guard against it. What would you need to see from us to feel confident the integration will actually land?" Why it works: it names the feeling first, then asks what evidence would settle it, which is the right response to a Trust Deficit.

3. Clarifying question: "What are you comparing our rate with?" Then: "It sounds like the comparison is the sticking point. If the other rate covers a narrower scope without the support you would need, the true cost of switching later may be higher than the difference today. What would you need to see to compare the two on equal terms?" Why it works: it tests the block, reframes to the cost of inaction, and ends on a calibrated question.

4. "Thanks for making the time. I know you have five minutes, so I will be direct. Your operations lead told me the manual reporting is costing the team time each month, and I want to show you one thing that addresses it. What would be most useful for you to see in the time we have?" Why it works: it respects time, gives one relevant reason, and ends with a question the stakeholder can answer.

5. You stay quiet. You let the pause sit, keep your breathing steady, and wait for the client to speak first. If the silence continues, you say: "It sounds like the number is worth thinking about. What would help you decide whether it fits?" Why it works: the pause gives the client room to reveal the real concern, and the question is calibrated, not a yes/no close.

- Quiz answers:
- 1. B. A B2B decision involves several people, each with a different role and concern, so you map everyone who influences or approves it.
- 2. C. Freezing feels safer than deciding when a client fears the wrong call, which is the pattern behind Regret Avoidance.
- 3. B. A clarifying question tells you which friction block you are facing before you respond; discounting or defending the number treats it as a dispute about a figure.

- 4. C. A.R.T., MEDJAY's own framework, ends with a calibrated how or what question, never a yes/no close and never a trade.
- 5. C. The pause lets you settle your breathing and voice and signals that you are considering the concern, rather than reaching for a script.

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